

11 Teaching the saxophone

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Saxophone teaching and learning comprise a diverse field. Every student is an individual, as is every teacher; study can be at any level from elementary to conservatoire or university; it can take place in one-to-one or group situations; and of course there are many different musical idioms to explore using the saxophone. It is difficult to imagine a ‘complete’ guide to teaching and learning the saxophone. However, I shall try to offer at least a personal view of what I consider to be some of the essential factors, common threads running through good teaching and learning at all levels.

Although there are a very few exceptional saxophonists who are truly self-taught, learning usually occurs through a process of interaction between students, teachers and institutions. The goals of this learning process are: the awakening and refining of the latent talent and musical imagination which is there to a greater or lesser extent in all saxophone students; the equipping of the student with the skills, techniques, judgement and experiences to draw upon in giving the imagination a voice, making communicative and accurate performances. These performances may be made by playing from written music, from memory or by ear, in as many of the different styles of music available to saxophonists as possible or desired.

Music is a complicated subject. It has physical, emotional and intellectual components, which all need to be addressed. There is a long continuum of levels of achievement; through the learning process the effort of the student, guided by the teacher possibly in the environment of an institution, is directed towards gradually improving the communicative range and technical standard of their playing. Incremental improvement, focused through realistic goals, is, in my view, a key to successful learning at all levels, from absolute beginner to doctoral candidate. For example, some students may be only moderately committed to music, viewing it as an amateur pastime or as one of many competing interests. While they may not aspire to a professional standard of playing, as long as there is a sense of motivation towards discovery and at least small improvements, their

encounter with music and the saxophone is likely to be a positive one. Likewise, I observe that even the finest players continually seek to monitor and improve their playing, and remain curious and open-minded in their attitude to playing long after they have ceased formal study with a teacher. In this sense, the student–teacher relationship is really, for the serious student, a launch-pad for a lifetime of self-motivated learning.

Instrumental learning can take place in groups, particularly in early stages; however, it is usual at some point that, for any student whose interest is beyond the minimum, a one-to-one student–teacher situation will form a substantial part of the learning process. Both student and teacher may be thought of as having clear roles in the learning process. The student’s role, first and foremost, is to be interested, curious and motivated to learn at least partly from within themselves. Successful students are willing to do daily practice, take initiative in their work and see the teacher as a guide rather than as a substitute for their own work. It is hoped that their initial interest will spring from an enjoyment of listening to music as much as playing it, and the student will seek to make connections between the two activities as improvements are made. No teacher, no matter how gifted, can play an instrument on behalf of a student. Ultimately, the responsibility for learning lies with the student. Those with an early understanding of this are inevitably the ones who improve the most. The teacher, meanwhile, has a role as an explainer, awakener, sharer, encourager, demonstrator, inspirer and co-explorer. It is up to the teacher to channel the student’s talent and motivation through a disciplined and progressive approach, setting sensible yet challenging standards on an individual basis, appropriate for the level of each student.

A good teacher is honest with the student in assessing work, offering praise where deserved, constructive criticism and occasional censure if required. I have seen good teachers of many different personality types; some are outgoing, some are reserved, some informal, some formal and so on. What they all share is a commitment to playing a positive role – whether in a one-off lesson/masterclass or in a long relationship – in using lesson time to help the student’s musical personality bloom, passing on their interpretative and technical knowledge to enable the learning player to improve their communication of musical ideas. This provides a basis upon which the student can build in individual practice.

Institutions provide a wider musical environment. An institution which is committed to music provides a community of interest, an atmosphere both of support and healthy competition, and creates opportunities for students to use their skills in group playing. Often, they provide instruction in the academic sides of music – theory, history, composition, arranging – either as a support to instrumental study or, in advanced courses, as ends in themselves. Keyboard study, aural training, study on other woodwind instruments and specialist work on jazz improvisation may be obtainable as well. These are all invaluable opportunities, which, at elementary level, add to the fun of playing (especially group playing) and, as higher levels are reached, enable the student to gain a wide variety of performing/learning experiences aside from solitary practice, and enter into a broader musical world. A single saxophone teacher may not be able to provide all of these experiences in one-to-one lessons, but can and should encourage students to take advantage of as many opportunities to learn as are possible or appropriate.

Overcoming technical difficulties: approaches, examples

During the course of any student–teacher relationship, long or short, the teacher will be faced with problems in the student’s playing which must be overcome. The teacher’s role is rather like that of a doctor: teachers must correctly diagnose the causes of problems and then take action to correct them. In diagnosing problems, teachers will listen, observe and sometimes ask questions about how the student is carrying out actions. Fixing problems is the task most generally associated with teaching, and it is a complex area requiring thought and sensitivity. With problems in technique, sometimes straightforward explanations of how physical actions should be performed are enough to put students on the right track. At other times, teachers may draw upon a repertoire of analogies and models, verbal or physical, to help the student along. I believe that the use of such models and analogies are of great assistance in teaching. They reduce complicated physical interactions to an easily understandable level and because they simplify complex tasks in students’ minds, aid in creating good habits and confidence in playing. And, of course, as the technically adept performer

tries to minimise actions and effort, so the adept teacher will seek to find succinct formulae for getting concepts across so students can quickly understand them and succeed in achieving them in reality.

Here are some examples of how I might approach certain general and specific problems.

(1) I use the syllabic method outlined in Chapter 6 to teach and practise reading rhythms, articulations and in creating tone-colour models. I sing or 'say' musical examples a lot in demonstration to my own students, at all levels, and I encourage them to do the same in practice. Even if the pitches of a melody are sung incorrectly, it is an excellent way to solidify musical shapes in the imagination and to get an instinctive sense that playing is a realisation of sounds which begin in our minds (whether the student is intellectually aware of this or not). It also prepares the tongue, in particular, for the actions it will need to carry out in actual playing. Likewise, in teaching phrasing, singing is of great use, because it models the musical shape without the use of the fingers, which are often a distraction when phrasing is of concern. With young students new to the concept of phrasing, singing words to match the phrases is of assistance in understanding the commonly used analogy between musical phrases and speech.

(2) When helping a beginning pupil form an embouchure and get a first sound, rather than wasting too many words on embouchure and potentially confusing the pupil, I simply demonstrate a model of the embouchure using my index finger in my mouth instead of the mouthpiece; the pupil imitates this, using a mirror if necessary. Then we transfer the 'practice' embouchure to the instrument itself, perhaps using the reed/mouthpiece set-up alone as an intermediate step. It only takes a couple of minutes, yet it gives the student a valuable point of reference and a meaningful, physical paradigm for the shape his or her mouth needs to take.

(3) In starting a vibrato, I return to the embouchure on the finger and ask the student to hold the finger in the 'practice' embouchure while saying the syllables YUYUYUYUYUYUY . . . or WAWAWAWAWA . . . thus causing the jaw to undulate slightly. While the tongue is partially involved in saying these syllables in a way in which it will not be in actual playing, as long as the student's attention is focused on the jaw movement, this 'practice' vibrato can quickly be transferred to the mouthpiece/instrument. Again, having a physical paradigm to which to relate the actions involved in

vibrato is invaluable in making a fairly easy and painless beginning in this often troublesome technique.

(4) Many students at one time or another face the problem of having a constricted sound caused by an embouchure which is too tight. Even once aware of this problem intellectually, it can be a difficult habit to break. To force the pupil to loosen all excess pressure on the mouthpiece/reed I might ask them to blow plenty of air through the instrument – but without allowing the reed to buzz and create a tone. Once used to this new looseness in the jaw and facial muscles, the tone may be attempted again, usually with better results.

(5) The diaphragm can be a difficult muscle to identify in one's own body. It is worth getting students to recognise its uses in everyday life, or in feeling its movement during laughter. Once identified through such analogous activities, the diaphragm and its function become much more apparent to the saxophone student.

(6) Beginning students tend to think one note at a time, often therefore creating interrupted, distorted or uneven phrases. When trying to teach even breath support across fingering exchanges, particularly in slurs, one effective technique is for the teacher to stand close behind the student and reach around the student's body, working the keys of the saxophone while the student concentrates on blowing consistently. This is particularly useful for breaking the habit of adjusting support as the resistance of the saxophone changes between differing fingerings, for example when moving across the break:



(7) In working towards reducing finger movement away from the keys, it can be useful to put some double-sided tape on the keys. This will not prevent the fingers from leaving the keys, but will certainly make the pupil physically aware of what is happening in a way that simply watching in a mirror (another way of dealing with this problem) may not. When used in conjunction with simple scale-based exercises, slow and fast, a pupil can usually break long-ingrained habits of poor finger and hand position.

(8) Squeaking is a problem which virtually all saxophonists face at least occasionally when learning. It can happen for a number of reasons: poor or incorrectly assembled reed/mouthpiece, instrument problems, embouchure problems, tonguing problems or poor support. Harmonic noises are sometimes mistaken for squeaks and these can also be caused by many of the above reasons as well as by poor fingering co-ordination. Although the teacher will have to observe the playing carefully in order to determine the cause, as an instinctive first response it is often a good idea to suggest that the student takes less of the mouthpiece into the mouth. Or, they might imagine the mouth in the shape of an 'overbite', i.e. tuck the lower teeth/lip back further under the upper teeth, closer to the tip of the reed. This allows the reed to be more under the control of the lip and, if tightness is a problem, forces the player to relax the embouchure to get a sound. Once the immediate squeaking is solved, the student's confidence will return and the underlying problem can be addressed.

By no means do I suggest that the techniques of teaching I have outlined above are the only way of teaching, nor are they particularly original; most are commonly used by many experienced teachers. However, it is worth remembering that these methods are widely used because they are successful – and they are successful because they relate the actions used in playing the saxophone to models that every student can comprehend and relate to without excessive physical or intellectual effort. They are logical and engender confidence by persuading the student that they already know how to accomplish a task. The student is enabled to get a physical 'feel' for the techniques of playing almost immediately, and this is of great value even if a full intellectual understanding comes only much later. This general approach can be used through all educational levels, whether teaching concepts to a young player for the first time, or making fine adjustments to an advanced player's technique. When used in conjunction with clear explanations and an encouraging attitude, the teacher can usually lay a sound technical foundation upon which the student can build.

Issues of broader musicianship

In addition to helping to overcome problems in the mechanics of playing the saxophone, a teacher must also oversee the wider musical development

of the pupil. In my view, two issues are of paramount importance. First, it is essential that saxophonists, who have such a diverse repertoire (including standard works, transcriptions, avant-garde contemporary works, light music, jazz, rock and pop; roles ranging from concerto soloist, chamber music, orchestral instrument, big band section, jazz combo, rock group, to name just a few), develop a strong sense of historical and stylistic context. Second, students should gradually be encouraged to take a creative role in music making, eventually finding a personal way of expressing themselves – a possibly unique voice on the instrument. These aims may seem paradoxical. The key from the teacher's point of view is to set parameters and encourage creativity within them.

Taking the first point, in building an understanding of context it is obviously valuable to have a sense of variety in a teaching regime: lessons may include work on long notes, scales and arpeggios, exercises, studies, pieces played by the student, duets, pieces played with piano if the teacher has this skill, and improvisation. Of course, with a beginner, it takes time to work up to all of these things. But in my own teaching, as early as I can, I try to have a beginning student play at least one scale from memory and a mix of solo, duet and accompanied pieces in both classical and popular styles. Time may not permit each bit of material to be examined each lesson, but I try to make an assignment each week of a small body of work which typically includes, at different times, at least some of the following items: some material to be played without music, some material to be played using printed music, some work containing progressively graded technical challenges and some which are pieces for fun or review, some work to be played alone, some to be played together, some pieces the student may already know and some which require them to decipher a new tune. Occasional sight-reading in lessons is a useful discipline.

As a student progresses beyond the beginning stages they may be allowed to set more of the agenda, pursuing interests that they may have, but the teacher should generally try to make sure that students do not close themselves off from any one style of music prematurely. Even at the college level, I find it of value to have a wide range of technical work, studies, repertoire of all types, duets, orchestral excerpts and so on. Of course, different college programmes will place more emphasis on classical music or on jazz/popular music. But even at this level, why not keep encouraging students to develop a multiplicity of skills? Those on classical courses, in

my opinion, should be encouraged to develop at least a minimum proficiency in improvisation, and likewise those on jazz courses could benefit from at least a limited encounter with what is now a rich repertoire of concert music for the instrument.¹ Similarly, all advanced student saxophonists should be familiar with all members of the saxophone family and can benefit from some study of other woodwind instruments. All of these experiences aid musical development, offer new perspectives on music and techniques, encourage confidence by discouraging fear of the unknown, and obviously add to the range of skills which can be drawn upon in the working musical world. Within the environment of a school, university or conservatoire, it is usually possible to create the necessary opportunities for these studies if they are not all available within the weekly study with a single saxophone teacher. At any rate, versatility is a key to understanding and appreciating context and idiom and is in my view something that teachers should continually encourage in their students. It is true that eventually most saxophonists seem to specialise in certain broad areas to a greater or lesser extent – but it is to be hoped that this occurs naturally through instinct, being drawn to certain music and by having enough work to choose between, rather than as the result of a limited education.

In working more specifically with interpretation and in trying to develop a sense of personal expression, the Socratic method – that is, teaching by asking questions – is an effective technique. Asking a student what form a piece is in, what mood it has, what characters they are trying to make as it develops, how does the music make them feel – all of these questions require the student to listen to what they are doing, engender a personal involvement with the music and help to crystallise ideas in the student's mind much more clearly than if the teacher simply says, 'this is how it should be done'. Even if the student comes up with what the teacher regards as crazy ideas, it can be the beginning of a dialogue which allows the student a creative input.

Occasional memory playing and improvisation are, again, useful disciplines in getting beyond the concerns of technique and note-reading. In interpretation, as with technique, judicious demonstration by the teacher is often helpful, as is playing together with the student (duets or even on the same melodic line) – for example, to get the feel for rubato over particular phrases. To modify the well-known saying, an aural picture is worth a

thousand words. Taking part in larger groups (bands, orchestras, jazz and pop ensembles) is absolutely essential for learning, as well as being fun. This sort of work is a powerful motivating force and reinforces the work being done one-to-one with interpretation and, especially for young students, rhythm. Involvement in a chamber-sized group, such as a saxophone quartet or a small jazz group, is particularly useful, because in rehearsals students learn to converse and collaborate in interpretation rather than always awaiting instruction from teachers and conductors.

Learning needs to be directed towards goals, so that the practice has a purpose which helps the student remain motivated. The goals are performances, which can come in all shapes and sizes and can play a role right through the learning process. For the beginning player, the weekly lesson is in itself a performance of sorts. As time goes on, performance goals of varying degrees of pressure might include playing in band or other ensemble concerts; playing to family; entering for examinations such as the British Associated Board exams or American solo and ensemble 'contest'; taking part in masterclasses or workshops; playing a piece at a school concert; auditioning for youth groups, courses and colleges; or taking part in an international solo competition. All of these goals are appropriate for different students, at different times.

A sensitive teacher will try to guide students individually through a progression of increasingly challenging goals, which the student will enjoy as well as deriving educational benefit. Learning music without these performance goals, no matter how elementary, is rather like learning French but never using the language to converse. Music is a communicative art and the saxophone is a vehicle for this communication; saxophone teachers should never lose sight of this idea amidst all of their technical teaching.

In conclusion, a couple of points can be made. First, the most successful saxophone students are those who want to learn, practise daily, listen to music, and use their imaginations as they address musical and technical challenges. Without these basic elements, even an excellent teacher will fail to make much of an impact. Second, the best teachers I know, the ones most able to inspire and guide these attitudes in their students, are those who lead by example; they are still curious to learn new things, hear new ideas and increase the communicative range in their own playing. Where both the student and teacher are motivated, the learning process can be an immensely rewarding experience, particularly as the saxophone provides

such an unusually diverse world to explore together. While the saxophone was once thought of as a 'limited' or 'extra' instrument, during the past century it has developed beyond all recognition, capturing the public imagination and gaining an enviable, perhaps uniquely wide, repertoire. The future of the instrument certainly seems bright. The saxophone is now one of the most popular instruments to learn and qualified teachers are widely available. With the saxophone as a vehicle, the sky is the limit as to what musical results may be achieved.